ancient Hindu temples.[10] In a number of instances Buddha statues too large to be removed have been converted into Hindu deities or simply concealed from sight by the building of a wall. According to the well-known Bengali scholar and archaeologist Dr Nagendranath Vasu,[11] the great temple of Jagannath at Puri is said to have one such hidden statue of the Buddha concealed behind a wall of the shrine to Surya, the existence of which is denied by the temple authorities, so it is impossible to know if Dr Vasu's claim was based on anything more than rumour. Enquiries are not made easier by the fact that this is one of those temples to which non-Hindus are forbidden entry, although Jains and Buddhists are now allowed in – provided they can prove Indian ancestry.

This brings us back to Puri and Jagannath, and those three curious images of Krishna and his brother and sister that are annually paraded before the vast crowds of the *ratha yatra*. The Jagannath temple is the very heart and soul of Puri and Odisha and its people's beliefs, and the first point to be made about it is that the temple itself has been attacked and violated perhaps more often than any other temple in India.[12] By one account it has been plundered nineteen times, the first by the Rashtrakutas in about 800 and the last in 1881, when the members of a local religious cult known as the Alekha or Mahima Dharma raided the temple and burned its three images in the street.[13] Sixteen of these raids were led by Muslim generals, for the most part motivated by politics rather than religious fanaticism. Despite all these depredations the Jagannath has come through. It is a survivor.

But what was there in Puri before that first attack in 800?

The Jagannath temple's legendary origins were first set out in the *Purusottama Mahatmya*, one of many books that make up the *Skanda Purana*, the longest of the eighteen Puranas and believed to have first been assembled in the